

# Hardheaded

Your skull is the most complex part of your skeleton. It is made up of 22 bones, but only your lower jaw bone can move. The others are fused together to form a superstrong case that protects your brain and the main sense organs. It also forms a foundation for your face, shaping how you look.

WOW!

The U-shaped hyoid bone in your lower jaw is the only bone in the body that is not attached to another bone. It provides a moving base for the tongue.

*Eight thin but incredibly strong bones form the domed part of your skull.*

## TIGHT FIT

The skull bones of a newborn baby are loosely joined by soft tissue. This allows the skull to expand as the baby's brain grows. By about the age of 18 months, the soft tissue is replaced by bony joints called sutures. These lock together like the pieces of a jigsaw puzzle to form a rigid case.

*Each eye socket is a ball-shaped hollow area with a hole at the back for the optic nerve. This nerve carries information from your eye to your brain.*

*A triangular hole in the front of the skull leads to an air passage behind the nose called the nasal cavity.*

*An adult has a full set of 32 teeth, firmly rooted in the bones of the upper and lower jaws.*

## ▲ SIDE VIEW

*The sutures, where most of the skull bones are joined together, are clearly visible in this side view of a skull.*